

MULTIRACIAL COMPLEXITIES

The Self & Social Identities

What Race
Is She?





Asian



Latino



Black/White

Personality and Social Psychology Bulletin

Impact Factor: **3.3** / 5-Year Impact Factor: **4.7**

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Believing Is Seeing: The Effects of Racial Labels and Implicit Beliefs on Face Perception

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Abstract

Two studies tested whether racial category labels and lay beliefs about human traits have a combined effect on people's perception of, and memory for, racially ambiguous faces. Participants saw a morphed target face accompanied by a racial label (Black or White). Later, they were asked to identify the face from a set of two new morphed faces, one more Black and the other more White than the target. As predicted, y theorists, who believe traits are immutable, perceived and remembered the target face as consistent the racial label, whereas incremental theorists, who believe traits are malleable, perceived and

Ambiguous Target Face



"Black" drawing



"White" drawing



(Gaither, Babbitt, & Sommers, 2018, PSPB)





Race-Known



Race-Unknown

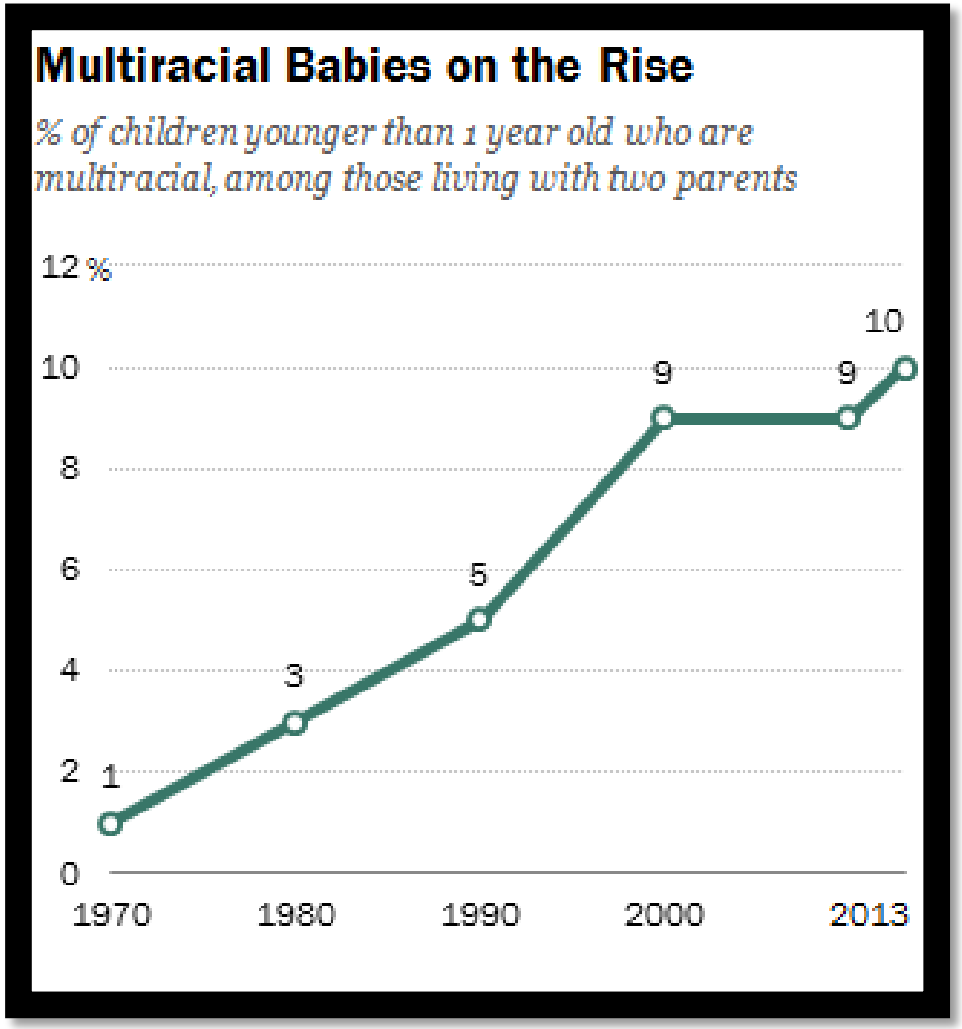
MULTIRACIAL IDENTITY

The 2011 U.S. Census found 2.9% or 9 million people identified as being mixed race

- **32% increase since 2000**

Black/White is most popularly reported followed by Asian/White

By 2015 this demographic will be 21% of the population



Evidence of Biracial Identity Flexibility

- **<u>Biracial people have several identity options:</u>**
  - **Minority or majority group membership**
  - **Multiracial or hybrid identity**
  - **Ignore racial boundaries and want to just be human**



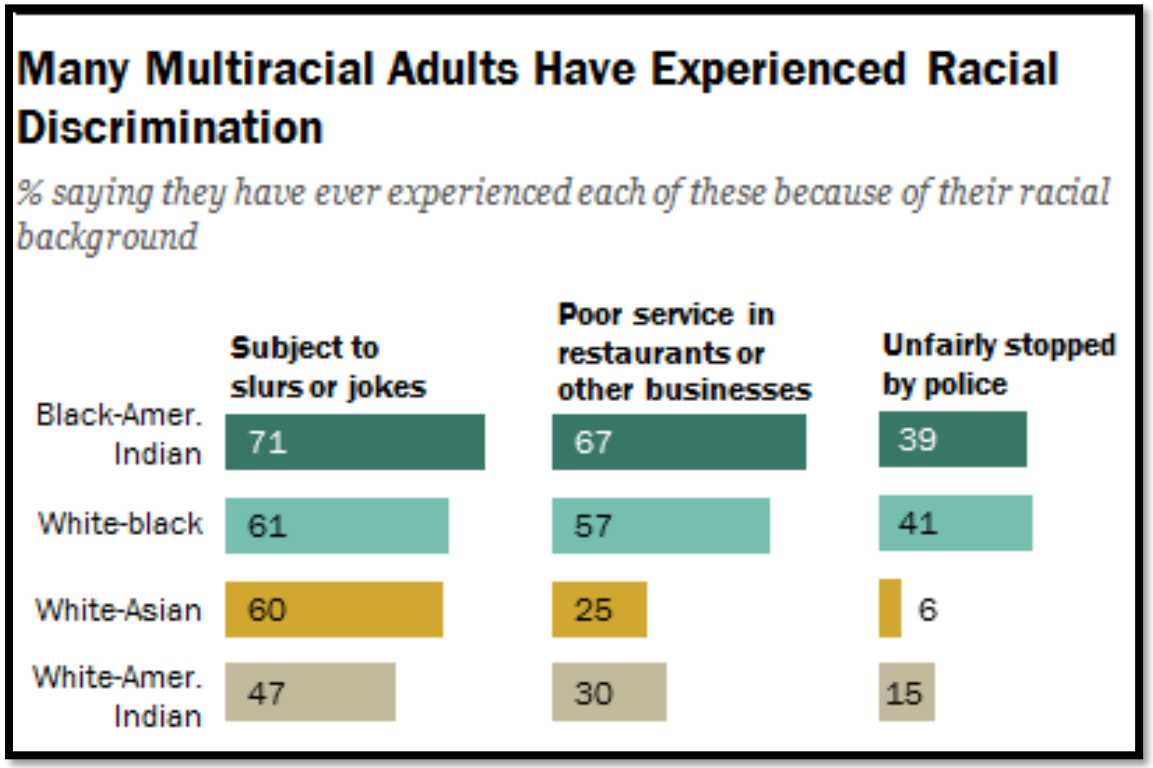
Having to Choose



- **Biracial individuals face unique challenges in navigating their social environments, and “having to choose” is a main source of emotional conflict**

Negative Outcomes

- Over 14 studies highlight difficulties with forming a sense of self causing lower well being
  - Constant questioning: ***What are you?***
- Higher rates of social isolation, discrimination, and disapproval



Positive Outcomes

- Over 19 studies found overall multiracials feel positive about their multiple identities
  - Appreciate and empathize with both backgrounds, buffers effects from stereotypes
- Function within both majority and minority environments



Biracials in Cross-Race Interactions?

- Context and racial exposure can alter biracial Black/White individuals' identity

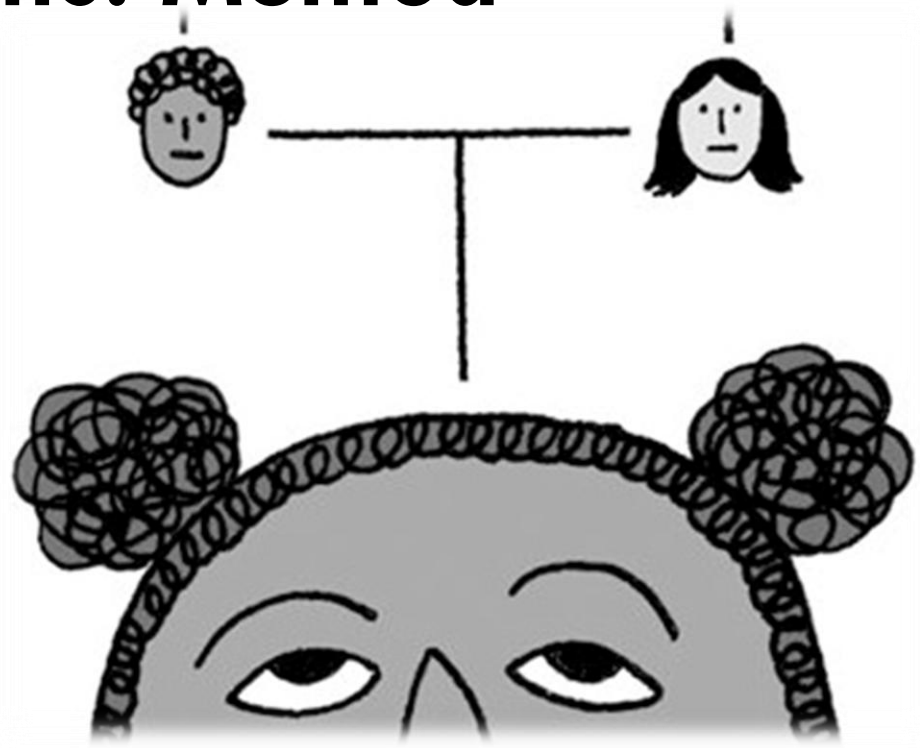
- But comparable effects have not been studied within actual social interactions

- Does thinking about one racial identity over the other affect social behavior?



Biracials in Interactions: Method

- 56 biracial Black/White young adults were recruited from the Boston area



- Randomly assigned to write either about their mother or father's racial/ethnic identity

- Videotaped, 5-minute interaction with either a Black or White "confederate" participant, discussed affirmative action

(Gaither, Sommers, & Ambady, 2013, JESP)





NONVERBAL BEHAVIORS

- **People monitor their nonverbal behaviors less**

- **Nonverbal behaviors can be a more accurate measure of experienced emotions**
  (e.g., Dovidio et al., 2003; Norton et al., 2006; Shelton et al., 2005)

Do you know people who have benefitted from Affirmative Action?



Black-Primed Biracial Participant, Black Partner

(Gaither et al., 2013 JESP; Gaither et al., 2015 Frontiers; Naidu, et al., 2025)

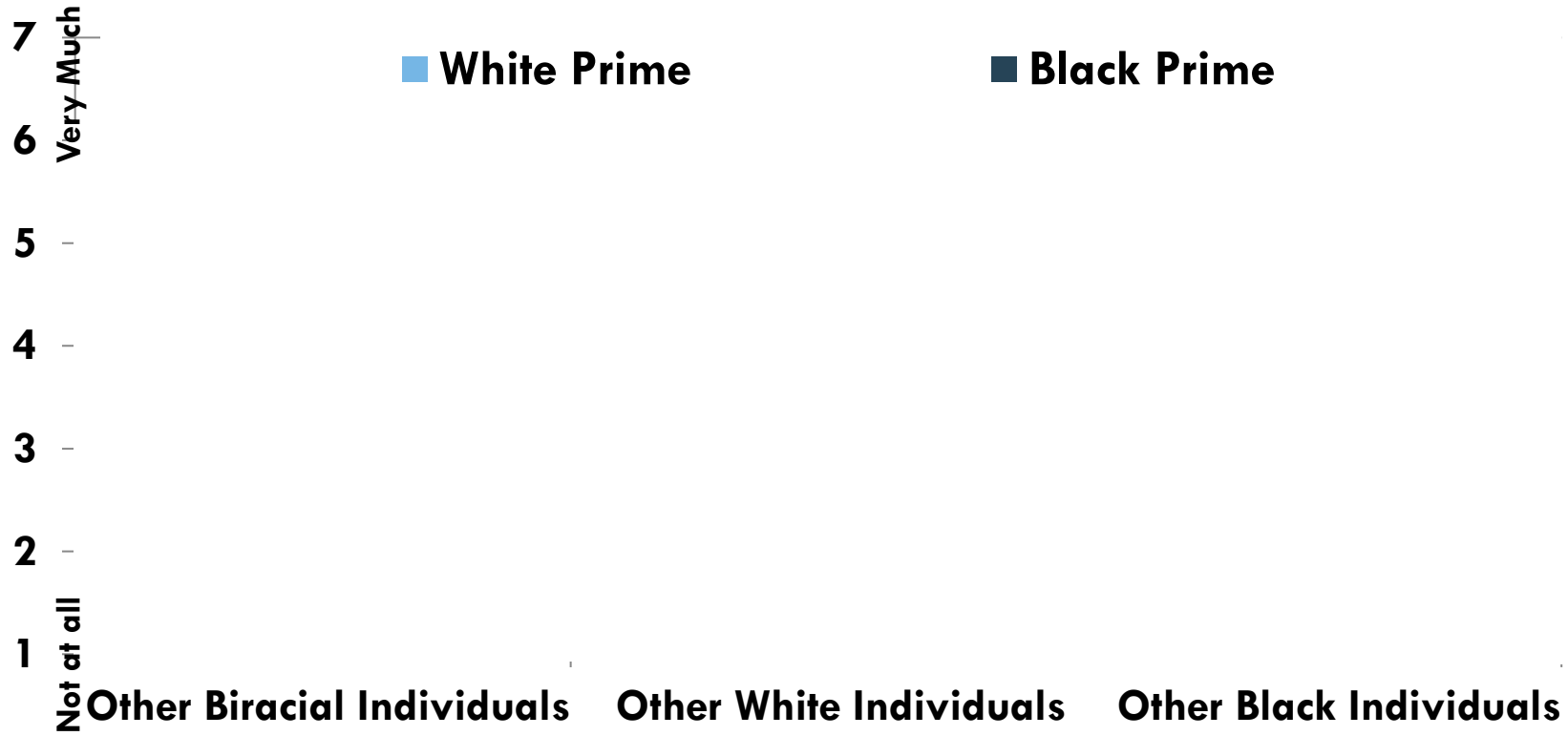
Do you know people who have benefitted from Affirmative Action?



White-Primed Biracial Participant, Black Partner

(Gaither et al., 2013 JESP; Gaither et al., 2015 Frontiers; Naidu, et al., 2025)

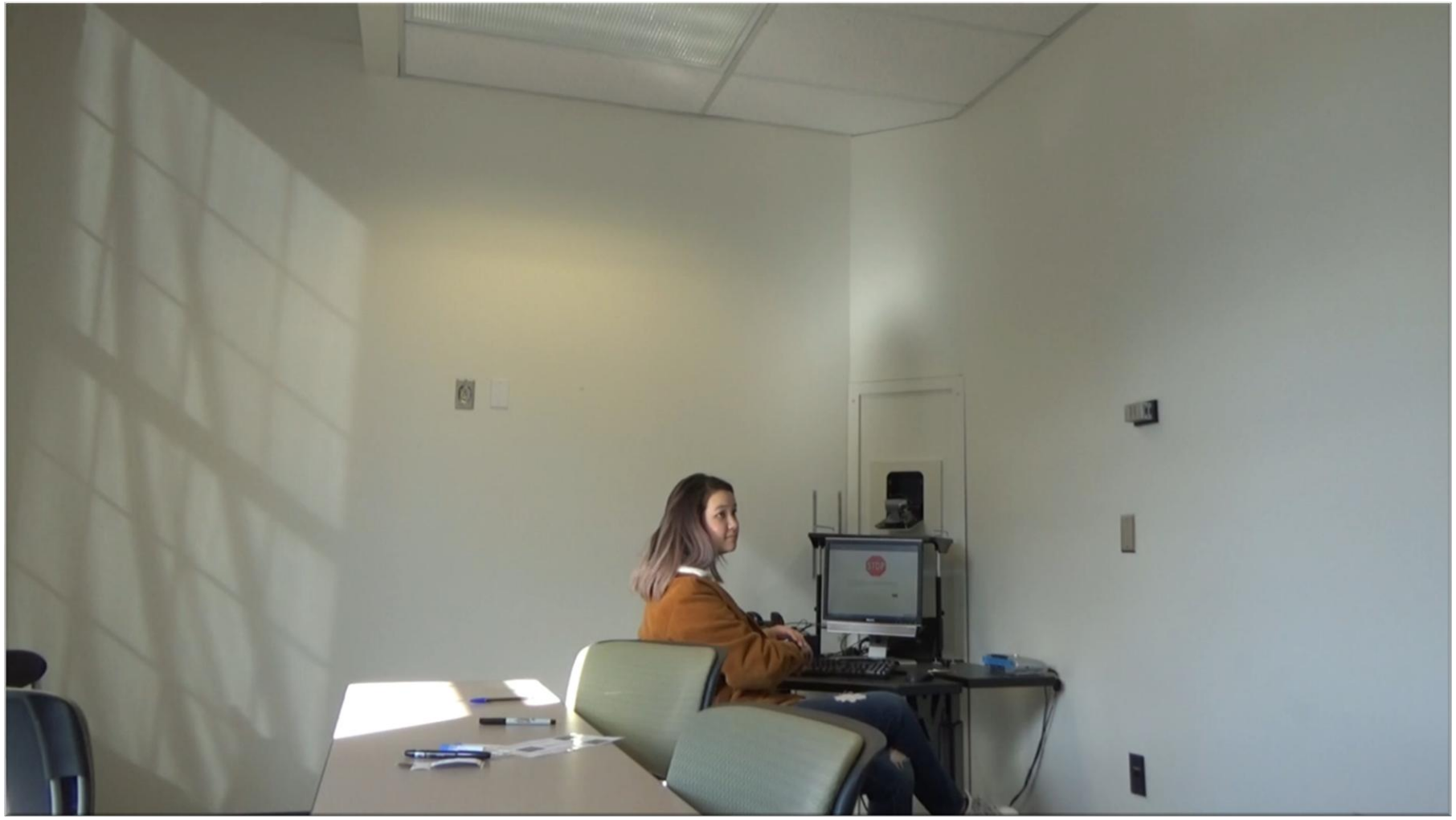
Biracial Racial Identification



Other White Individuals: $t(32) = 2.37$, $p < .03$, $r = .39$

Other Black Individuals: $t(32) = 2.47$, $p < .02$, $r = .40$

(Gaither, Sommers, & Ambady, 2013, JESP)





Dr. Analia Albuja—now faculty @ Northeastern University

BIOLOGICAL RESPONSES TO IDENTITY DENIAL

121 Biracial and
126 Bicultural
participants

(Albuja, Gaither, Sanchez, Straka, & Cipollina, 2019, JSI)

WHAT DO YOU THINK?

Is racial ambiguity necessarily a disadvantage?

Why might knowing that someone is multiracial change how we perceive them, even when their appearance stays exactly the same? Does it always change?

Why do you think people have difficulty categorizing multiracial individuals?

PERCEIVED VS. ACTUAL RACIAL IDENTITY

Racial Identification: The importance an individual's racial or ethnic group plays for their own self-image

Phenotypic Prototypicality (PP): the degree to which an individual's physical appearance is perceived to be prototypical of their group

What aspects of PP do you think is related to perceived racial identity vs. actual racial identity?



PHENOTYPIC PROTOTYPICALITY

PP is known to be particularly relevant for understanding minorities' racial identification

PP is linked to higher rates of discrimination and prejudice experiences

The more minority you look, the more you tend to identify with that minority group



WILKINS: STUDY 1



Research Question: tests the hypothesis that high PP Blacks will be perceived as more highly identified with their racial group than low PP Blacks

- **Method:** 96 undergrads (majority White) rated either high or low PP Black faces using the Twenty Statements Test for how important each trait was to the person in the photo
  - I am…a son, African American, roommate, helpful, etc.

- **Results:** Participants who viewed a face high in PP ranked the African-American attribute as more important to the target's sense of self than low PP faces

WILKINS: STUDY 2

Research Question: Same as Study 1



- **Method:** 104 undergrads (majority White) rated either high or low PP Black faces on a 0 (not at all) to 6 (very much scale):
  - Overall, his racial/ethnic group membership has very little to do with how he feels about himself.
  - The racial/ethnic group he belongs to is an important reflection of who he is.
  - The racial/ethnic group he belongs to is irrelevant to his sense of what kind of person he is.
  - In general, belonging to his racial/ethnic group is an important part of his self-image.
- **Results:** Participants who viewed a face high in PP thought the target had a higher racial identification than those who viewed a target low in PP

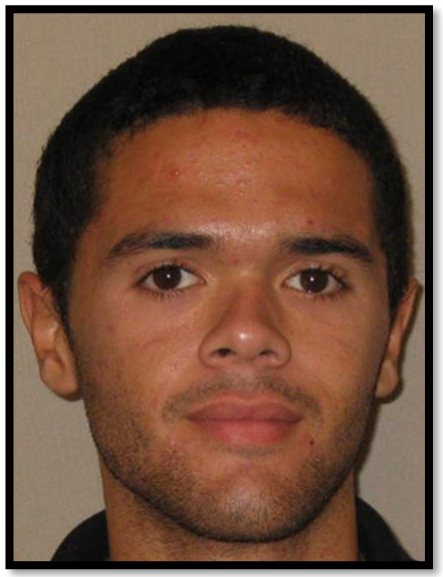
WILKINS: STUDY 3



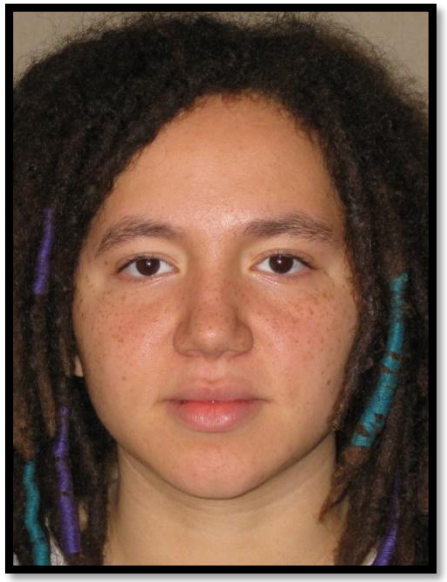
Research Question: Is it possible that Blacks who have higher PP actually racially identify more strongly and are people accurate in knowing this?

- **Method:**
  - Black and Latino people were photographed and self-reported their racial identification
  - Coders rated PP and how much the target racially identified
- **Results:**
  - PP is positively correlated with perceived and actual racial identification for both Latinos & Blacks
  - Suggests outside perceivers are accurate in judging how much a Black or Latino individual may racially identify—thoughts?

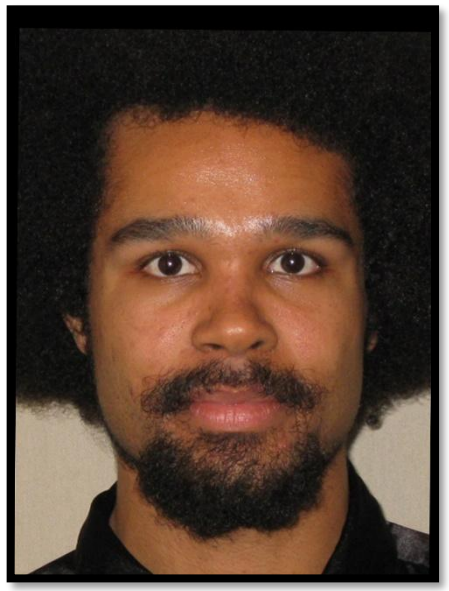
HOW MUCH DO I IDENTIFY WITH MY RACE?



A



B



C



D

DISCUSSION

What other types of perceived identities could show variability in how accurate others are guessing levels of actual identification?

How does biracial identity research fit into our existing identity frameworks?

How does having two racial identities or two cultural identities compare to having two other types of identities? Which theories would help explain those similarities or differences?



NEXT WEEK

Gender Identity & Representation

Discussion Post Due Monday 2pm!

Paper 1 Due Thursday by 9am!